

Report Part Title: Politico-Military Relations:

Report Title: Europe Rediscovered Peacekeeping?

Report Subtitle: Political and Military Logics in the 2006 UNIFIL Enhancement

Report Author(s): Alexander Mattelaer

Egmont Institute (2009)

Stable URL: <http://www.jstor.com/stable/resrep06671.9>

JSTOR is a not-for-profit service that helps scholars, researchers, and students discover, use, and build upon a wide range of content in a trusted digital archive. We use information technology and tools to increase productivity and facilitate new forms of scholarship. For more information about JSTOR, please contact support@jstor.org.

Your use of the JSTOR archive indicates your acceptance of the Terms & Conditions of Use, available at <https://about.jstor.org/terms>



Egmont Institute is collaborating with JSTOR to digitize, preserve and extend access to this content.

JSTOR

Politico-Military Relations: How Friction Dilutes the Promise of Strategy

On paper – or in military powerpoint briefings – operations often look surprisingly clear and straightforward. In practice, operations hardly ever run as smooth as one might wish for. Incomplete or ambiguous information, organisational factors, multinationality, conceptual problems and, quite simply, changes in the situation, add various layers of friction that, at the very least, complicate the planning and conduct of operations. In the worst case, they doom an operation to utter failure. This section analyses three categories of such friction that were particularly salient in the planning and implementation of the enhanced UNIFIL. At a fundamental level, these three categories – informational, organisational and conceptual friction – can be related to politico-military relations. In this domain, a contrast can be observed between a political logic characterised by a focus on flexibility and self-interest and a military logic requiring clarity, unity and a sense of realism. Of course, many of the problems discussed here are not new, nor do they pertain only to the case of UNIFIL.²⁰ This section merely chronicles the experience in one particular operation in order to contribute to a broader awareness of the complexity of military crisis management.

Informational Friction

The existence of different attitudes to the management of information constitutes a first category of friction between the military personnel and their political masters in UNIFIL. Military officers are in need of a maximum of information in order to fulfil their mission – both in terms of quantity and clarity. Any issues concerning the sensitivity of information would be managed by the protection of information. On the political level, national sensitivities make the availability of maximum information a distant pipe dream. All issues that cannot be clearly agreed upon are shrouded in diplomatic ambiguity or mere silence. In the most obvious sense, this issue becomes manifest in the bizarre use of terminology. In UN documents, for example, Hezbollah is grouped together with other groups under the label of ‘armed elements’. Military planners objected to this practice as it precludes more detailed analysis of the motives and capabilities of different groups. UNIFIL’s mandate is commonly labelled as ‘robust’, yet many amongst the military personnel have already done tours in other operations – with what they consider genuinely robust mandates – and

20. Cf. e.g. M.C. Williams, *Civil-Military Relations and Peacekeeping*, London, International Institute for Strategic Studies, Adelphi Paper 321. Incidentally, Mr. Williams currently serves as UN Special Coordinator for Lebanon.

scorn such attempts at diplomatic social constructivism. As hunting is a popular pastime in Lebanon, anybody carrying small arms in the area of operations is commonly labelled as a hunter, even though it is clear to UNIFIL patrols that some of these alleged ‘hunters’ are not hunting at all. Similarly, UNIFIL officers admit they have to tailor their discourse to suit their interlocutor when liaising between the IDF and the LAF. The omnipresence of semantic ambiguities has two functional implications for the planning and conduct of operations, bearing on the use of intelligence and the formalisation of planning documents.

Intelligence has traditionally been a highly problematic issue in UN peacekeeping. As the connotation of espionage and secrecy made intelligence a bit of a dirty word in UN circles, it simply did not exist for a long time.²¹ As peacekeeping operations became gradually more complex, however, the need for good situational awareness grew more acute – for the purpose of force protection as well as for guiding strategy.²² In UNIFIL, various troop contributors are actively gathering operational intelligence, for example using collection assets on board of the ships that form the MTF, but the dissemination of information remains a very sensitive issue. Both in New York and in the field, one can observe that the sharing of information is mainly based on personalities and goodwill between individuals, rather than being the procedural rule. Part of the explanation lies in the absence of a closed ICT system for transmitting documents, which means that very sensitive information is being left out because of the risk of documents being intercepted. Yet the more systemic absence of standard policy and procedures of intelligence management has an important impact on the effectiveness of staff work. As information is treated on a strict ‘need-to-know’ basis – a bit of a surprise in a peacekeeping context, where the ‘need-to-share’ has important merits of its own – there emerges a parallel system of intelligence where the real inside knowledge does not reach all relevant units and thus undermines the unity of effort. For example, the in-house assessments of the conflict parties are not distributed to all staff officers in the planning section of the UNIFIL headquarters, even amongst the personnel from NATO states. Similarly, the UNIFIL Joint Mission Analysis Centre is responsible for threat analysis, but it is not automatically plugged into all information channels.

The most critical consequence of the diverging attitudes on information management can be found in the formalisation of planning guidance and documents. In UN peacekeeping, the Security Council only approves a single document – a resolution – that contains broad objectives rather than detailed planning guidance. In the words of one DPKO official, this means that the planning work has

21. See H. Smith, ‘Intelligence and UN Peacekeeping’, in: *Survival*, Vol. 36, 1994, No. 3, pp. 174–192.

22. See P. Shetler-Jones, ‘Intelligence in Integrated UN Peacekeeping Missions: The Joint Mission Analysis Centre’, in: *International Peacekeeping*, Vol. 15, 2008, No. 4, pp. 517–527.

to be based on *assumptions* of what the Security Council wants. Subsequently, the UN Secretariat itself is in charge of formulating guidance down to the lower levels. Often, this takes the form of emails and conversation rather than formal documents. As a result, the limited information that is available does not always trickle down the command chain. In the planning cycle of the UNIFIL enhancement, time constraints as well as political pressure short-circuited the process. Correspondingly, a paper trail of planning guidance was not available. Planners in the field were of the opinion that there was hardly any real guidance to work with at all.

It seems that the issue of limited formalisation of guidance is related to political sensitivities. As one general explained:

On the one hand, we as military personnel, we need a clear mandate and clear orders. The diplomats and political staff, on the other hand, need flexibility. They hope for the best as far as the future is concerned. This is highly problematic for military planners: above all we need to be realistic, and we must be able to manage the worst scenario-case as well.

The very issue of including worst-case scenarios and other politically sensitive questions constitutes an obstacle to formalising planning documents. For example, the phase two UNIFIL CONOPS that the SMC prepared in early 2007 was not signed off by the Under-Secretary-General. The DPKO Office of Operations reportedly objected to some wordings – most notably references to Hezbollah – that were considered as being too explicit. This in turn triggered conceptual problems for the SMC planners: “How can you expect us to be able to justify a list of force requirements including artillery units and main battle tanks if we are not allowed to mention that there are potential bad guys out there?” The non-adoption of military-drafted documents because of being diplomatically non-palatable was considered standard practice in the eyes of UNIFIL planners. The requirement of absolute consensus on all textual details in planning documents de facto implied that many delicate questions were only answered by silence.

Organisational Friction

The second main category of politico-military friction in UNIFIL consists of questions and disagreements about appropriate organisational structures. The UNIFIL enhancement plan necessitated a redesigning of the UNIFIL command and control structure on the level of the UN headquarters in New York as well as the UNIFIL headquarters in Naqoura. These reforms fuelled heated debates along multiple fault lines: disagreements between different troop contributors,

disagreements between the European troop contributors and the UN as an organisation and disagreements between military and political personnel.

At the level of the UN headquarters, this dynamic concentrated around the establishment of the SMC. As the SMC idea was born out of frustration with or even mistrust of the standard UN command capabilities, it constituted a direct confrontation between the UN Secretariat and the European troop contributors. As these new troop contributors de facto imported their NATO-inspired approach to operations, the SMC also bred resentment amongst traditional UN troop contributors such as India, Pakistan and Bangladesh. Their major complaint was that the SMC introduced double standards in peacekeeping operations by giving the Europeans a preferential treatment.²³ Consequently, the budgeting committee in the UN General Assembly decided that the SMC would be gradually downsized and subsequently absorbed by the DPKO structure by mid-2010. A third aspect to this debate was that the SMC constituted the single purely military structure in what is otherwise an overwhelmingly civilian staff. Compared to the UN staff, the military personnel from European countries introduced a completely different mindset on how to plan and conduct military operations. What they considered as military professionalism, however, was not greeted with much enthusiasm at the UN. In the view of UN staff, the rationale behind the SMC was flawed in the sense that it failed to acknowledge that UN peacekeeping works as a highly decentralised system light on top-level bureaucracy. Furthermore, as most of the SMC personnel did not have previous UN experience, it cost significant efforts to get the first rotation of SMC personnel familiar with the UN system – leading to an initial loss of planning capacity, from the UN's perspective, rather than a gain. As such the SMC remained somewhat of a *Fremdkörper* in the UN system over which opinions remained quite literally oceans apart.

Similar dynamics can be observed in the workings of the UNIFIL field headquarters in Naqoura. In its structural set-up, the headquarters displays quite a few 'anomalies' compared to military standards. For example, the joint operations centre is not part of the J-3 operations section, but resorts immediately under the Deputy Chief of Staff Operations – thus elevating the real-time conduct of operations one level higher up in the chain of command. Information operations, as another example, do not even fall under the remit of the Chief of Staff, but resort under the Director of Political and Civil Affairs. On the one hand, these anomalies can be seen as the consequence of the organic growth of the headquarters over the course of UNIFIL's history, yet on the other hand they can also be read in terms of politically charged turf wars. The fact that NATO coun-

23. See Hatto, op. cit., p. 191-194.

tries occupied the vast majority of crucial command posts fostered a lingering sense of the ‘West against the rest’ in the UNIFIL headquarters. This was amplified by the fact that European military personnel informally adopted NATO planning doctrine. This in itself is hardly surprising, as there is hardly any substantial UN doctrine available whereas NATO doctrine is a widely accepted multinational standard. Unintentionally yet quite inevitably, this led to the partial exclusion of other (non-NATO) troop contributors. Similar to the rivalry between the SMC and the Office of Operations in New York, a complicated relationship came about inside the field headquarters between the military staff and the office of political and civil affairs. While this was, by and large, gradually overcome through personal contact and growing mutual appreciation, the existence of different expectations of how peacekeeping should work assured that the UNIFIL command and control structure inevitably operated in a medium full of cultural resistance.

Conceptual Friction

The third and arguably most important category of friction when it comes to its impact on operational strategy consists of a set of conceptual problems dogging mission planning. These range from the internal coherence of the mandate, over a partial mismatch between operational planning doctrine and the UNIFIL context, to the issue of how to deal with worst-case scenarios. Together, these issues can be linked to a more overarching debate on the benefits and drawbacks of the UN’s decentralised approach to directing operations.

In the workings of the Security Council, the drafting of mission mandates is by and large a diplomatic preserve.²⁴ The main complaint heard amongst the military personnel tasked to implement these mandates is that they often contain internal inconsistencies and may be dangerously out of sync with the situation in the field. Throughout UNIFIL’s history, this has been a major problem. When UNIFIL’s original mandate was issued in 1978 – in the middle of the Lebanese civil war – it was heralded as “a document that combined morality, naivety and folly in about equal proportions”.²⁵ For example, it mandated UNIFIL to assist the Government of Lebanon, but it failed to recognize that there was at the time no effective government to speak of in the first place. This problem repeated itself with the UNIFIL enhancement in 2006. As described earlier, the expanded force received a dual mission: to assist the LAF and to ensure that its area of operations is not used for hostile activities. Without clear prioritisation, situa-

24. See Williams, op. cit., p. 22.

25. R. Fisk, *Pity the Nation: Lebanon at War*, 3rd ed, Oxford, Oxford UP 2001, p. 134.

tions occur where these two missions may imply conflicting courses of action. For example, if the LAF is unwilling or unable to tackle the construction of armed facilities in the UNIFIL area of operations – in order to avoid splits along sectarian lines within the LAF – to what extent can UNIFIL disregard its role as LAF assistant in order to fulfil the second part of its mission? It was noted above that both conflict parties exploit this diplomatic ambiguity inherent to the mandate. Yet this ambiguity has the same effect internally: all personnel inside the operation are free to interpret the mandate and define what constitutes success along their own preferences. For example, the military personnel from European contributors are generally more inclined to emphasise the ‘ensuring’ part of the mandate than the rest of the staff.

Those elements that can be interpreted as restraining the scope of the mandate to a peacekeeping rather than an enforcement operation provide military planners with intractable conceptual problems. In the most obvious sense, the strategic end-state of the operation – the Lebanese government exercising full sovereignty throughout its territory – goes far beyond anything UNIFIL could hope to achieve on its own. Many of the elements in the enhanced UNIFIL’s operational design are coherent in their own right but simply go beyond the mandate and the means of UNIFIL. For example, one of the decisive points in achieving the strategic end-state would be to deal with the issue of arms in the possession of others than the Lebanese authorities. As the responsibility for disarming the armed elements lies with the LAF – or within domestic politics in Lebanon, for that matter – UNIFIL cannot hope to achieve its own long-term plan on its own. Rather, it can only foster conditions that favour a course of events in the right direction. As one general commented: “A real end-state for UNIFIL is very difficult to envisage. In that sense, our traditional planning doctrine based on the end-state concept simply cannot be applied.”

The question whether operational planning doctrine – especially NATO doctrine that is developed as a toolkit for war planning – is applicable in a peacekeeping context such as the one of UNIFIL is more than valid. While this operational planning doctrine has its merits in structuring the planning process, the key conceptual ideas – centres of gravity, end-state etc – are sometimes impossible to apply sensibly in a peacekeeping context. Put simply, the basic premise of operational art is that one achieves the end-state by neutralising the centre of gravity of one’s opponent. But if there is no clear opponent to begin with, this intellectual framework does not lead planners to a coherent plan. For example, the centre of gravity of the LAF was initially determined to be the establishment of a weapon-free zone between the Litani and the Blue Line. Apart from the fact that such a zone may never have existed in reality, this analysis seems to confuse an intermediate end-state with a source of strength – and thus serves little pur-

pose in orienting operational design. This is not to say that military doctrine is of no use in a peacekeeping context – far from it. Rather, the issue is that when there is a conceptual misfit between the military planning tools on the one hand and the political mandate and the operational context on the other, many critical questions (e.g. force sizing, troop to task analysis...) cannot be answered in any definite sense. In short, such a situation leaves much more room for diverging opinions on the basis of different hopes and expectations. This manifests itself most clearly in the management of uncertainty and contingency planning.

The relative prominence of contingency planning is one of the main features of the planning work in support of the enhanced UNIFIL. Such planning products are intended to cater for various ‘what if’ scenarios. Contingency planning is thus a reflection process designed to make an operation better prepared for future events – most notably worst case scenarios. As an intellectual discipline it is part and parcel of the professional military mindset, as a protective reaction against the infamous uncertainty and unpredictability inherent to military operations. Of course, to engage in contingency planning above the tactical level requires a minimum of extra capacity that can be spared from the day-to-day staff work. The surge in UNIFIL troops and capabilities in 2006 included an influx of a large number of staff officers well versed in operational planning doctrine. Both at the operational level and at the strategic level in the SMC, planners started working on contingency plans. This was driven by the awareness that UNIFIL would find itself caught in the middle of a shooting war in case the ceasefire would not hold. While the Force Commander explicitly requested such contingency plans, planners in the SMC were under the impression that their colleagues in the Office of Operations had little appetite for this sort of work. On the one hand, such contingency plans were drafted on the basis of politically incorrect future scenarios and would assume that one or several of the conflict parties would renege on their responsibilities under the ceasefire agreement. On the other hand, some in the chronically under-staffed and under-equipped UN secretariat were shocked to see so much energy and resources being spent on mere hypothetical worries. Over time, this situation gradually improved. Especially in the context of the Israeli offensive in Gaza in February 2009 – with tensions in southern Lebanon rising rapidly as well – SMC staff found that they were now “surprisingly well-understood”. The recent New Horizon non-paper prepared by DPKO in 2009 reflects this development too, as it explicitly calls for the fostering of a contingency planning culture.²⁶

26. *A New Partnership Agenda: Charting a New Horizon for UN Peacekeeping*, New York, UN Department of Peacekeeping Operations and Department of Field Support, July 2009, p. 31-35.

Several of the issues discussed above – the attitude to contingency planning and the usual absence of a strategic level of command – point at a more general feature of the UN peacekeeping system, namely the light and decentralised approach to directing operations. On the one hand, the UN approach to peacekeeping aims to avoid micromanagement and second-guessing the judgement of the commanders in the field. This decentralisation is also made possible by the fact that restrictive mandates reduce the need for permanent oversight. As one official explained: “The Force Commander’s hands are tied anyway: he is not allowed to overstep his mandate. You do not need a strategic command level because the Commander is so limited in what he can do anyway.” On the other hand, it can be argued that this decentralised approach is simply a budgetary necessity. The personnel capacity of the DPKO is very small relative to the scale of the UN’s operations.²⁷ A heavier, more centralised mission management structure would either require the DPKO budget to go up or the mission budgets to go down.

The discussions over the creation and role of the SMC already made clear that many of the European contributors, and especially their defence staffs, took issue with this philosophy. While the arguments above are internally coherent, they may be overtaken by events: when a peacekeeping operation suddenly finds itself in an environment that is dramatically different from the one envisaged in the mandate, it may urgently need new strategic guidance. Adding a strategic command level and increasing staff personnel at all levels would create some level of redundancy under normal circumstances but would also harden the structure against all sorts of contingencies that may cause the light approach to be derailed. In essence, whether one prefers one approach over another depends on how one wants to balance return on investment with risk management and thus boils down to a political choice. The UN approach to directing operations is much more cost-effective as long as the situation remains generally supportive and does not diverge too much from the one anticipated.²⁸ The downside is that this approach may carry greater risks when the envisaged plan is derailed by events taking a turn for the worse. Operations led by Western nations aim to minimise such risk as much as possible, but become exponentially more expensive. In the UNIFIL enhancement planning, the European troop contributors thus insisted on hardening the mission not only in terms of troops and capabilities, but also in command style because they anticipated that Lebanon might make for a volatile operational environment.

27. For example, in the summer of 2006 the Military Planning Service inside the DPKO consisted of only 16 staff officers.

28. Cf. the core argument offered by Hillen, *op. cit.*, that the UN as an organisation has precisely those characteristics needed for peacekeeping in a supportive political environment but lacks those required for managing complex military operations.